

Stop Hanging Pieces

Notice the threat, identify the defender, and check the move you intend to play.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Save the piece that is attacked

P. 3

02 A capture is safe only after the reply

P. 6

03 Find the threat before developing

P. 9

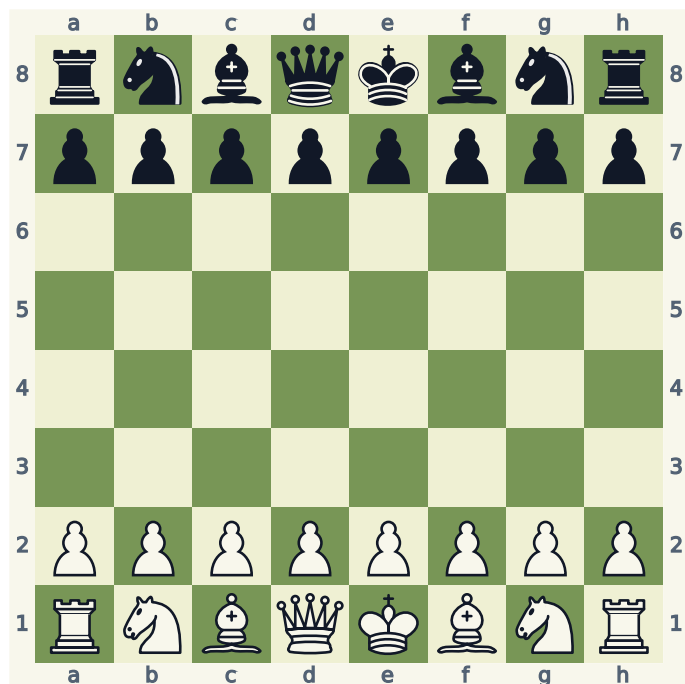
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

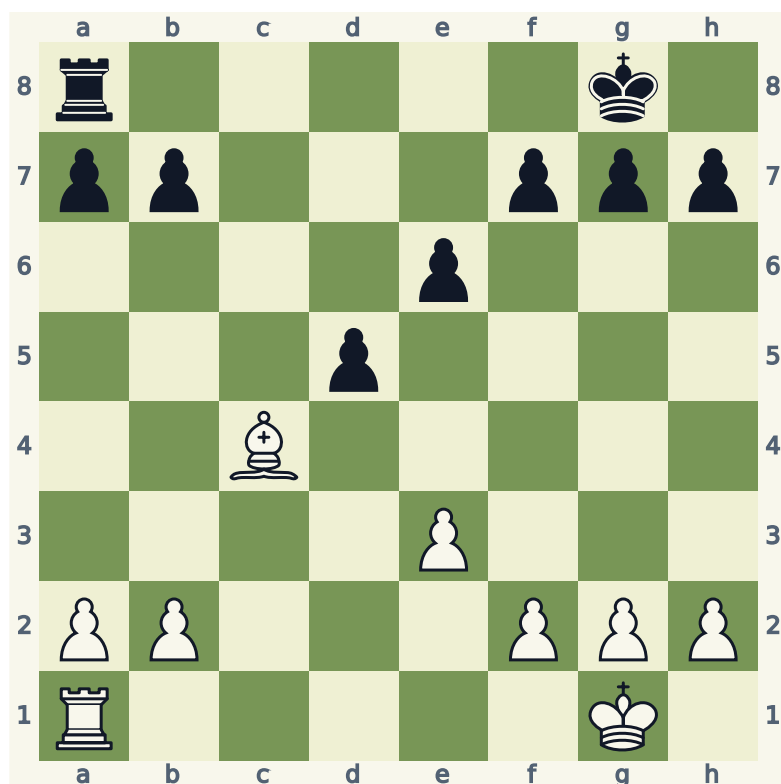
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Save the piece that is attacked

Before improving your position, deal with a piece that can be taken. Saving it requires a safe destination, not just a square that looks active.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. Black's pawn on d5 attacks the bishop on c4: black pawns capture toward lower rank numbers.
2. The pawn on e6 defends d5. The pawn does not defend the square directly in front of it.
3. The bishop can retreat along c4-d3. On d3 it is outside both pawns' attacks.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Bd3 Kf8

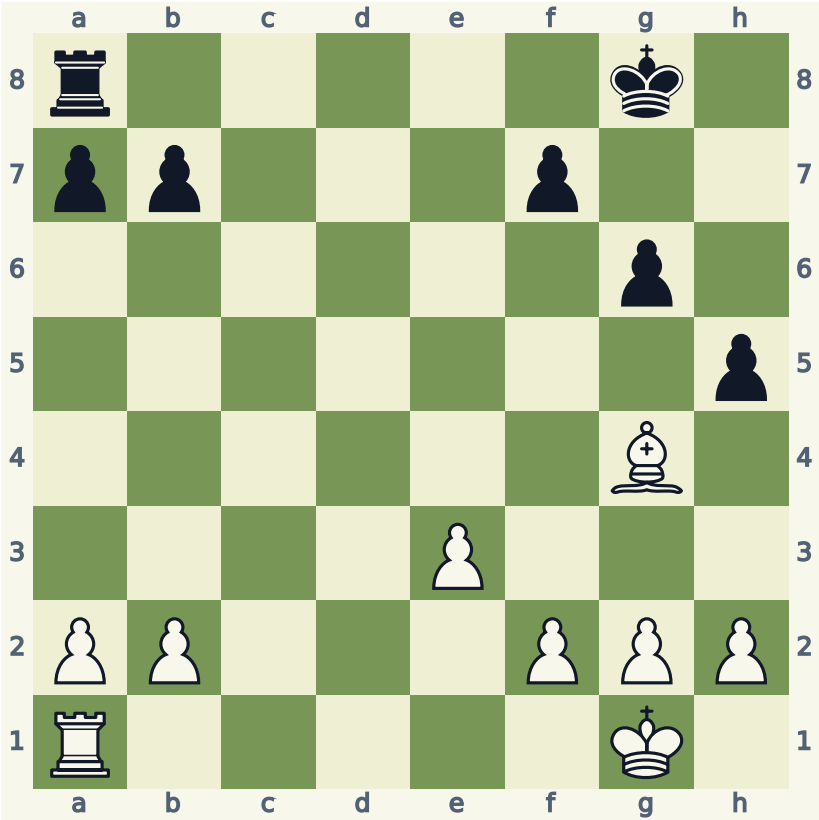
Start with the opponent's immediate capture: ...dxc4 would remove a bishop for no compensation. White should answer that threat now. Bd3 moves the bishop to a safe square and keeps it in the game.

After the quiet illustrative reply ...Kf8, the bishop is still safe. That reply is not forced; the point is to check the destination against all enemy attacks before choosing it. Retreating can preserve more useful activity than a material-losing advance.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. Which black pawn attacks the bishop on g4?
2. Does Bxh5 solve the problem? Write Black's reply and the material exchanged.
3. Name a safe bishop retreat and explain why it is safe.

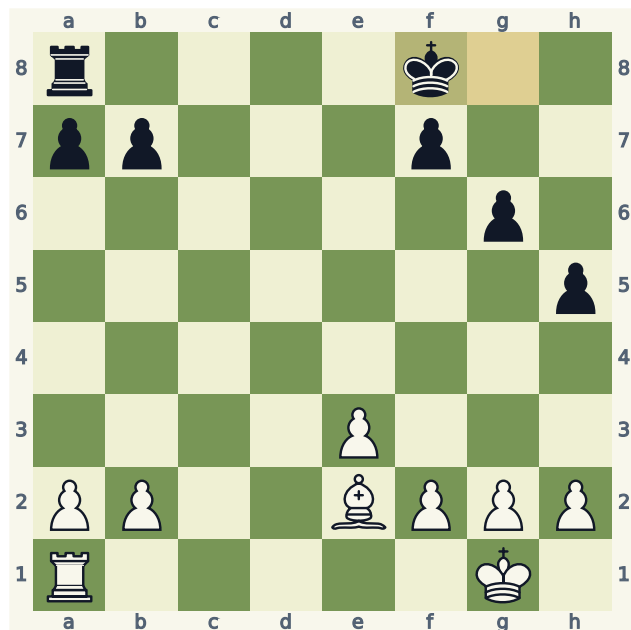
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): r5k1/pp3p2/6p1/7p/6B1/4P3/PP3PPP/R5K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Be2 Kf8

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The h5-pawn attacks g4. A pawn does not attack the square directly ahead of it; trace its two diagonal capture squares.
2. Bxh5 is met by ...gxh5. The g6-pawn protects h5, so White exchanges a bishop for a pawn and has not saved the piece.
3. Be2 is a safe example. The path g4-f3-e2 is clear, and no black piece attacks e2. Bd1 or Bh3 can also be considered if you verify their paths and destinations; this is not a one-move puzzle.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Bxd5 takes a pawn, but ...exd5 takes the bishop. The whole exchange gives up a bishop for one pawn. Count the resulting material, not the first capture alone.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

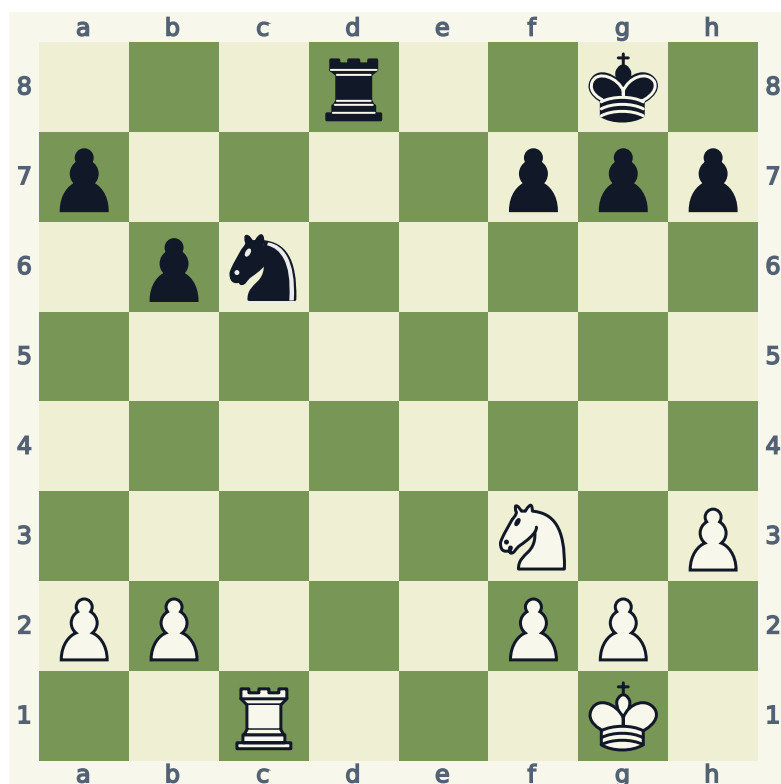
In your next three games, say which enemy pawn attacks each bishop before you move it. After a game, revisit one retreat and explain what material it preserved.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

A capture is safe only after the reply

An undefended piece can be a real opportunity. The useful habit is not "never take"; it is "take only after checking defenders and forcing replies."

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's rook has a clear path from c1 to c6.
2. A black pawn on b6 attacks a5 and c5. It does not protect c6.
3. Black can check on d1 after the capture, but White has already made an escape square on h2.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Rxc6 Rd1+ 2. Kh2

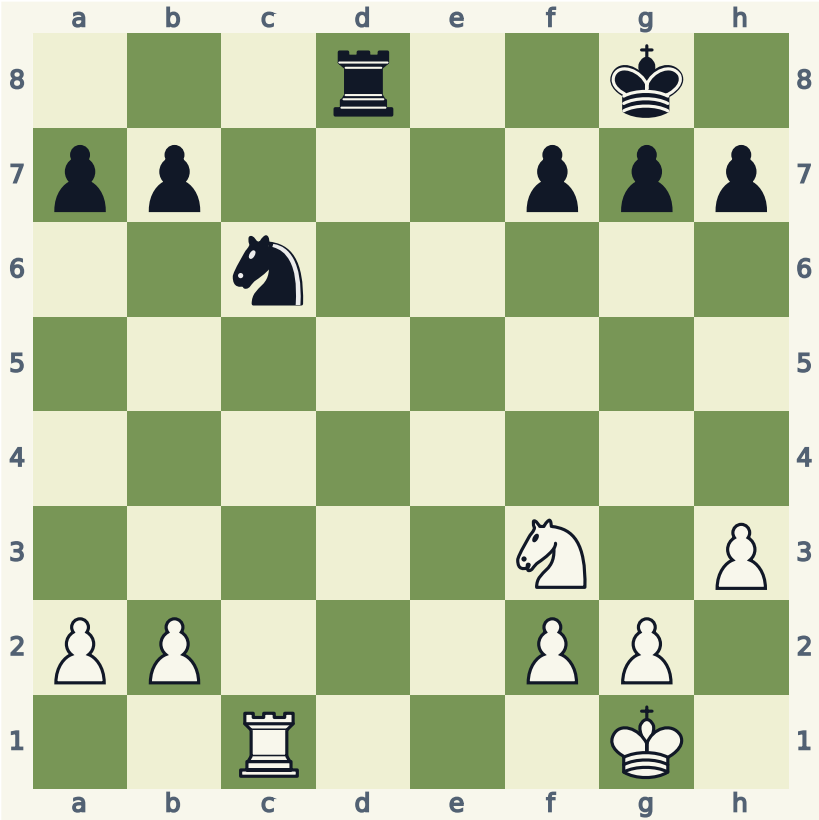
Rxc6 wins a knight. Before playing it, look for Black's strongest forcing idea: ...Rd1+. The white king can step to h2 because the h-pawn stands on h3 and h2 is not attacked.

The sample line stops after the check is answered. White keeps the extra knight; there is still a game to play. A capture can be sound even when the opponent replies with check, provided you can answer the check without returning the gain.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. What changed from Model A?
- 2. Calculate Rxc6 through Black's recapture. Who gets the more valuable piece?
- 3. Give a safe rook move if you decline the capture.

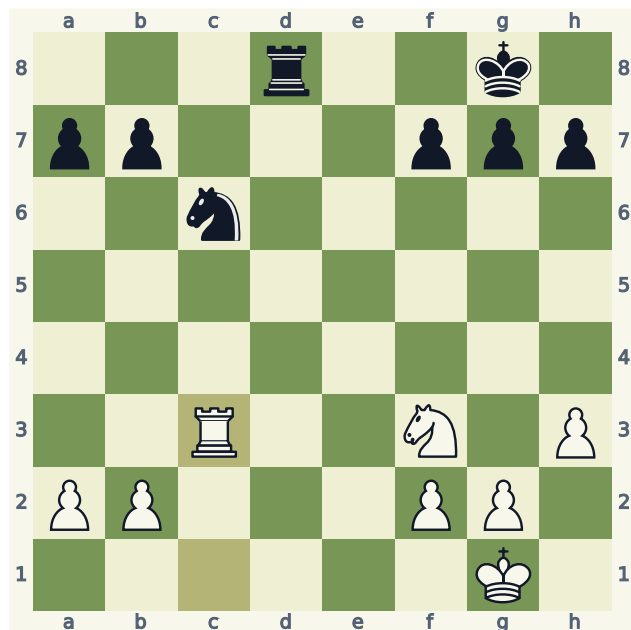
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 3r2k1/pp3ppp/2n5/8/8/5N1P/PP3PP1/2R3K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Rc3

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The black b-pawn is on b7, not b6. From b7 it attacks c6, so the knight now has a pawn defender.

2. $Rxc6\ bxc6$ trades a rook for a knight. Using rough values of rook 5 and knight 3, White gives up about two points of material. These values are guides, but there is no compensating attack in this exercise.

3. $Rc3$ is one safe example: the rook stays on the c-file and avoids the defended knight. $Rc2$ and a king move can also be reasonable. The required answer is the defender and the consequence, not a unique quiet move.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Defenders are about squares, not proximity. A pawn one square away may defend nothing relevant. Conversely, moving a pawn back one rank can turn an apparently free knight into a poisoned capture.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Pick any capture from a recent game. On a board, draw the defenders of the target square, then test every available check after your capture.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Find the threat before developing

Development is valuable only if it meets the position's immediate demands. An early queen attack is best answered by identifying the mating square and the piece supporting it.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The queen on h5 and bishop on c4 both attack f7.
2. The king on e8 cannot capture a queen on f7 while the c4-bishop protects that square.
3. ...g6 attacks the queen and blocks its diagonal h5-g6-f7.

WORKED SEQUENCE

3... g6 4. Qf3 Nf6

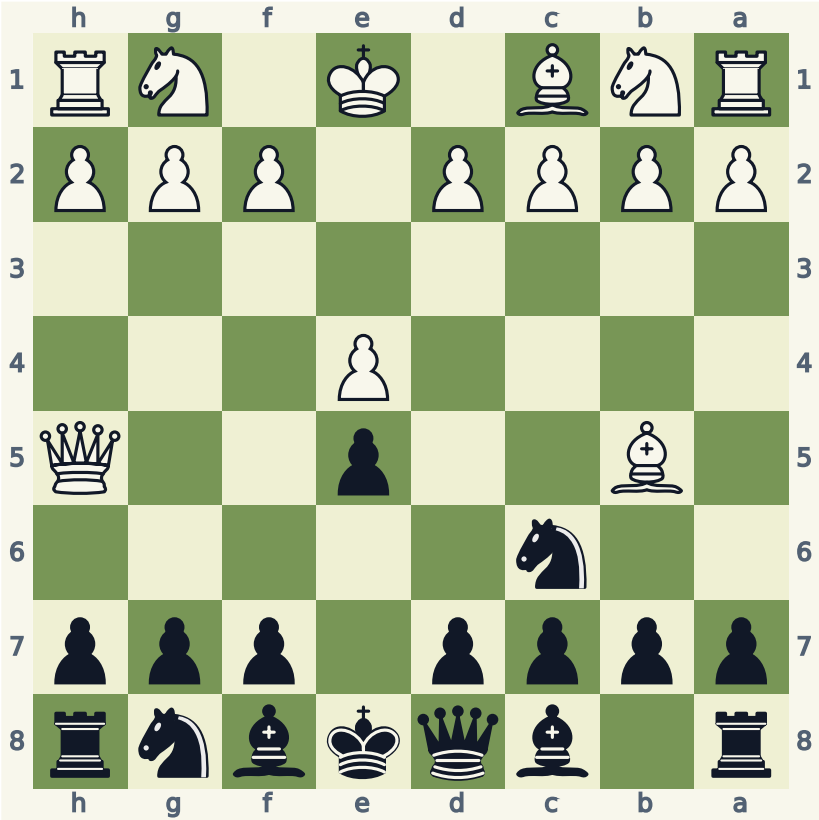
Black begins with ...g6, interrupting the queen's route to f7 while gaining time against the queen. After Qf3, the queen threatens f7 down the f-file instead.

Now ...Nf6 develops a piece and blocks that new line. The same developing move that failed on the first turn works on the second because the attack's geometry has changed. Always reassess after the queen moves.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



1. Which piece has moved compared with Model A, and what important square does it no longer protect?
2. Can Black now play ...Nf6? Test Qxf7+ rather than guessing.
3. After White withdraws the queen to e2, suggest a developing continuation.

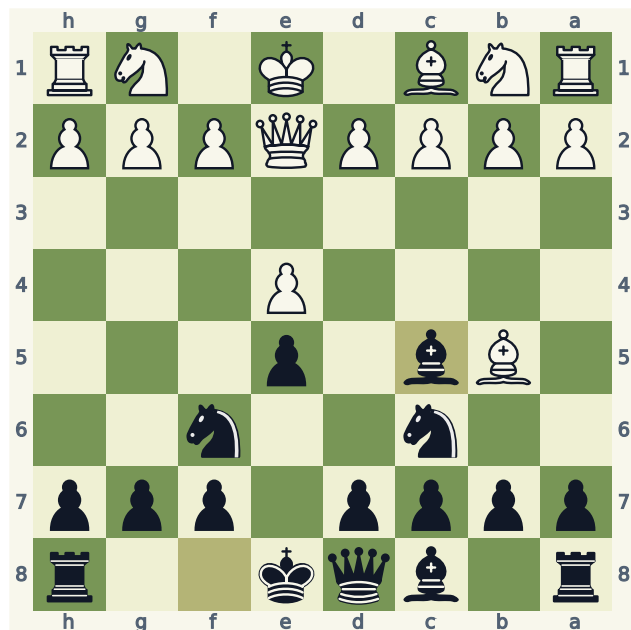
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): r1bqkbnr/pppp1ppp/2n5/1B2p2Q/4P3/8/PPPP1PPP/RNB1K1NR b KQkq - 3 3

Check your reasoning

3... Nf6 4. Qe2 Bc5

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. White's bishop is on b5 instead of c4. It no longer protects f7. The queen's attack looks similar, but the mating support is absent.

2. Yes. After ...Nf6 Qxf7+ Black can play ...Kxf7. The king is not moving into any white attack on f7. White loses a queen for a pawn; the check is not mate.

3. ...Bc5 develops the f8-bishop and eyes f2. Other sensible developing moves exist. The lesson is to inspect the actual support for a threat before importing a familiar response.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Playing ...Nf6 immediately attacks the queen but allows Qxf7#. An attack on the queen does not force it to retreat when it has checkmate available.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

When facing an early queen move, write the threatened capture and name its supporting piece. If you cannot name a concrete threat, continue developing after a safety check.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. Why can capturing the attacking pawn still lose a piece?
2. Does a black pawn on b6 defend c6?
3. Why does ...Nf6 fail with a white bishop on c4 but work with it on b5?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. Because another enemy piece may recapture. Calculate both captures and compare the material left.
2. No. It attacks a5 and c5. A black pawn on b7 attacks c6.
3. The c4-bishop protects f7, making Qxf7 mate. The b5-bishop does not, so ...Kxf7 is legal.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.